History Ch – 03 Nazism and the Rise of Hitler - Street

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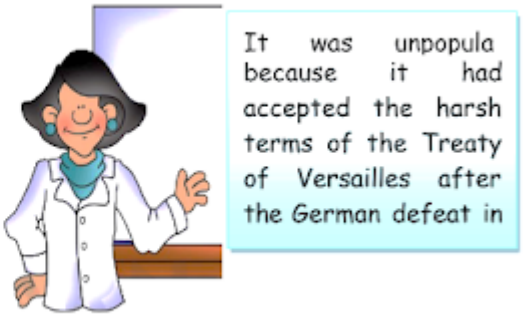
The First World War and Germany

The rise of Hitler to power in Germany is often attributed to the harsh treaties which were faced by Germany during the First World War.

➤ Germany fought the First World War along with Austria-Hungary against the Allies- England, France, and Russia. Germany was defeated in the war, and the German emperor abdicated the throne.

➤ After the war, Weimer Republic-a democratic government-was formed in Germany. All Germans including women got the right to vote in the

elections.



An artist's impression of the signing of the Treaty of Versailles after the First World War

Terms of the Treaty of Versailles:

- ➪ Germany lost all its overseas colonies
- ➪ She also lost one-third of its iron reserves and one-fourth of its coal reserves to France
- ➪ It was demilitarized
- ➪ She also had to pay a huge compensation of six billion pounds to the allies

➤ The number of unemployed youths and poor people increased in German society. Thus, socialism became a great force in Germany. Communists also made an uprising against the Weimar Republic but failed. The political atmosphere in Berlin was charged with demands for Soviet-style governance.

➤ There was deep economic crisis in Germany. When Germany refused to pay the allies in gold, France occupied its leading industrial area. To meet the economic crisis, the Government printed too much of German currency

(Mark). The value of German currency declined considerably, and the prices of essential goods and commodities rose.

➤ Eventually, the Americans intervened and bailed Germany out of the crisis by introducing the Dawes Plan. It redrew the terms of reparation to ease the financial burden on the country.

Germany and the Great Depression of 1929

➤ German investments and industrial recovery were totally dependent on short-term loans, largely from the USA.

➤ However, the world plunged into the Great Depression in 1929 when American stock market 'Wall Street Exchange' crashed.

➤ The Great Depression of 1929 further added to the miseries of Germany.

➤ After America withdrew the loans which it gave to Germany. By 1932, the industrial production on Germany declined to 40%. Millions of people became unemployed. This also led to increase in poverty.

➤ The economic crisis instilled fears among middle class Germans. They also feared the rise of socialism in Germany.

➤ Small businessmen, the self-employed and retailers suffered as their businesses were ruined.

➤ Big business was in crisis and the large mass of peasantry was affected by a sharp fall in agricultural prices.

➤ Politically, the Weimer Constitution was vulnerable to dictatorship. Article 48 gave wide powers to the President. He could impose emergency and suspend the civil rights of the citizens.

➤ Further, there was also political instability in the country. Within its short life, the Weimar Republic saw twenty different cabinets lasting on an average 239 days.

The above circumstances favoured the rise of Hitler in Germany.

Rise of Hitler

➤ Hitler was shattered by the German defeat in the First World War.

➤ He fought for Germany in the 1st World War and earned medals for bravery

➤ He joined the German Workers Party. Later, he became the leader of the party and renamed it the Nationalist Socialist German Workers Party. This party came to be known as the Nazi Party.

➤ Hitler was an excellent orator. His speeches moved the people. He promised employment, economic recovery of Germany, to undo the injustices of the Treaty of Versailles and to restore the dignity of the German people.

➤ He devised a new style of politics. Massive rallies and public meetings were held by the Nazis to display the strength of the party. Nazi propaganda also skillfully projected Hitler as a messiah who could deliver people from their distress. He captured the imagination of the Germans.

Hitler's excellent oratory skills won him the support of the people

Hitler Captures Power

➤ Hitler after becoming the chancellor of Germany issued the Fire decree of 1933. It suspended freedom of speech, press and assemble.

➤ He then passed the Enabling Act in 1933. This Act established dictatorship in Germany.

➤ Communists were sent to concentration camps by Hitler. All political parties and trade unions were banned except for the Nazi Party. The state had full control over the executive, legislature, judiciary and media.

➤ A secret state police called the Gestapo was formed. It had the authority to detain any person without any trial. Detained people were sent to concentration camps and torture chambers. The police and the state under Hitler gained the reputation of the most dreaded criminal state.

Economic Recovery under Hitler

➤ Hjalmar Schacht was given the responsibility of devising an economic recovery plan of Germany. He aimed at creating full employment through state-sponsored work creation programmers.

➤ This project resulted in the building of various German superhighways and the Volkswagen However, when Schacht advised Hitler against rearmament of the state, he was asked to leave.

➤ Hitler then planned economic recovery through the expansion of territories.

Hitler's Foreign Policy

➤ Hitler's foreign policy was successful in the initial years. He withdrew from the League of Nations in 1933, reoccupied the Rhineland and integrated Austria with Germany. He also annexed Sudetenland from Czechoslovakia.

➤ In 1939, Germany invaded Poland bringing it into war with France and Britain. In 1940, Hitler signed a Tripartite Treaty with Italy and Japan. Hitler at this time was at the pinnacle of his power.

➤ Hitler attacked the Soviet Union in July 1941. Hitler's forces however were defeated and were driven out of Eastern.

➤ Europe. It was after the USA entered the Second World War that the war took a decisive turn, and Germany was defeated in the war. Hitler committed suicide in 1945.

German armies captured Poland in September 1939

The Nazi Ideology

Theory of Racial Supremacy

➤ Hitler believed in the racial supremacy of the Aryans. According to the theory of racial supremacy, only the Nordic German Aryans were supreme in society. The Jews were placed in the lowest strata of society. The Jews were regarded as the fiercest enemies of the German Aryans.

➤ The theory of Darwin was wrongfully used by Hitler to justify imperial rule over conquered territories. He believed in acquiring new settlements for expanding the power and might of Germany. He expanded his territories eastwards towards USSR.

➤ The Nazis after assuming power sought to eliminate the Jews and physically disabled Germans. Along with them, the Gypsies and the black Germans were also detained in concentration camps

➤ Jews were treated as an anti-race, the archenemies of the Aryans

➤ The worst sufferers were the Jews. They were forced to live in miserable circumstances in the ghettoes. In the early years of Nazi rule, Jews were forced to leave Germany.

later years of Hitler's rule, the Jews were rounded up in concentration camps and gas chambers.

➤ Marriages between Jews and Germans were forbidden. Extramarital relations between Jews and Germans became a crime. Jews were forbidden to fly the national flag

➤ Russians and Poles were also considered subhuman and captured civilians of Russia and Poland were forced to work as slave labour

➤ Much of north-western Poland was annexed by Germany. Polish intelligentsias were murdered in large numbers in order to keep the entire people intellectually and spiritually servile

➤ Polish children who looked like Aryans were forcibly snatched from their mothers. If they passed the race tests they were raised in German families and if not, they were deposited in orphanages to perished

➤ Many of them died simply through hard work starvation and extreme cold.

➤ The Polish were forced to leave behind their properties and homes for the Germans who came to settle in Poland. Most of the Polish were put into concentration camps. Many of them were murdered in large numbers.

➤ Hitler's ideology was also related to the geopolitical concept of Lebensraum or living space. He believed that new territories had to be acquired for settlement. This would enhance the area of the mother country, while enabling the settlers on new lands to retain an intimate link

with the place of their origin. It would also enhance the material resources and power of the German nation.

Youth in Nazi Germany

➤ Hitler believed that by controlling education in schools, he will be able to spread Nazi ideologies in Germany. All Jewish teachers and children were dismissed from schools.

➤ School textbooks were rewritten. Racial sciences were used to justify Hitler's ideology of racial supremacy. Jews were painted as dishonest and untrustworthy in books.

➤ The Youth League of Nazis was founded in 1922 for educating German youths. Wars were glorified, democracy was condemned, and the Jews and disabled were hated in educational institutions apart from government-supported youth organisations, all other youth organisations were banned.

➤ After receiving physical training, the youth had to join the Labour Services at the age of 18 and had to serve in the army.

The Youth League of Nazis trained the youth in Nazi principles and ideologies. It also prepared them for the military.

Notions about Women in Nazi Ideologies

➤ The Nazis saw women as mothers whose main work was to become good mothers and rear pure- blooded Aryan children. They had to teach Nazi ideologies to their children.

➤ Girls were expected to maintain the purity of race and had to distance themselves from the Jews.

➤ All mothers were not equally treated in Nazi Germany. Those mothers who gave birth to undesirable, mental or physically unfit children were punished. Those who produced racially desirable children were awarded and honoured.

➤ Aryan children who deviated from the prescribed code of conduct were condemned and severely punished. Those who maintained relations with the Jews, Russians and Poles were paraded with shaved heads and were jailed.

The Art of Propaganda

➤ The Nazis used language and media carefully to propagate their ideologies. The words used to describe treatment to the Jews were deceptive. Nazis used words such as 'special treatment' and 'final solution' for mass killings of the Jews. 'Evacuation' was used for the mass deportation of people to gas chambers. Gas chambers were known as 'disinfection areas.

➤ Media was used to popularise the support of the Government. Jews and those opposing the Nazis were stereotyped. Socialists and liberals were attacked as foreign agents.

➤ Many propaganda films were made to create hatred for the Jews. The Nazis worked on the minds of the people and turned the attention of the Germans towards people labelled as enemies of the Nazis.

Crimes against Humanity

➤ The Nazis committed heinous crimes against humanity. Those people who raised their voices against the Nazi ideologies were beaten up by the police, jailed and sentenced to death.

➤ Many Germans remained silent to the crimes committed against humanity by the Nazis because of the fear of being jailed or losing their lives.

➤ About 6 million Jews were killed during Hitler's regime. About 1 million Polish civilians, 2,00,000 Gypsies and 70,000 mentally and physically ill Germans were killed.

➤ The greatest sufferings were endured by the Jews. Their elimination came to be known as the 'Holocaust'.

➤ The history and the memory of the Holocaust live on in memoirs, fiction, documentaries, poetry, memorials, and museums in many parts of the world today.